

A PLOTBREW WRITING WORKBOOK

THE ROMANTASY WORLDBUILDING WORKBOOK



Build worlds worth falling in love in.

What This Is

This is a worldbuilding workbook designed specifically for romantasy — fantasy romance where the world isn't just backdrop, but an active force shaping and pressuring the love story.

In romantasy, worldbuilding isn't separate from romance. The political marriage that forces enemies together, the magical bond that connects two people against their will, the ancient feud that makes love forbidden, the class divide that seems impossible to cross — these aren't setting details. They're the engine of your story.

This workbook helps you build worlds that create romantic tension by design.

Who This Is For

This workbook is for writers who want to:

- Build fantasy worlds that feel real and internally consistent
- Create external obstacles that pressure and test relationships
- Understand how geography, politics, magic, culture, and history can generate romantic conflict
- Move beyond generic fantasy settings to worlds that could only produce *your* story
- Develop worldbuilding that readers will want to live in

Whether you're writing your first romantasy or your tenth, whether you're a plotter who needs everything mapped before drafting or a pantsier who discovers your world as you go — this workbook meets you where you are.

How This Workbook Is Structured

Each section follows a two-part structure:

Part One: The Foundation

This is the worldbuilding itself — how your geography, magic, government, religion, economy, culture, or history actually works. These elements exist in your world regardless of your characters' romantic situation.

Strong foundations make your world feel real. Readers can tell when a world has depth versus when it's cardboard scenery hastily assembled behind the love story.

Part Two: [Topic] & Romance

This is where worldbuilding becomes romantic tension. Each section shows you how to mine its topic for obstacles, intimacy, stakes, and conflict specific to love stories.

A magic system isn't just about what spells exist — it's about what happens when one character is vastly more powerful than the other, or when a magical bond forces intimacy neither chose, or when using power for someone you love costs something real.

REMEMBER

You need both parts. A romance between a servant and a prince needs a believable class system (foundation) that actually creates stakes and obstacles for their relationship (romance application). Skip the foundation and your world feels thin. Skip the romance application and you're not using your world to its full potential.

How to Use This Workbook

You Don't Have to Do Everything

This workbook is comprehensive — intentionally so. Not every section will apply to your story. Not every question will be relevant.

Skip freely. If your story doesn't involve inter-species romance, skip that section. If religion isn't a factor, move past it. If your characters aren't part of an institution, those questions aren't for you.

The goal isn't to fill every blank. The goal is to build what your specific story needs.

You Don't Have to Go in Order

The sections are numbered for reference, not because you must complete them sequentially.

Some writers start with magic because that's the heart of their world. Others start with the political situation that creates their central conflict. Some build geography first because place shapes everything else.

Start wherever you have the most energy or the clearest vision. Let that section inform the others.

Focus on What Creates Stakes

As you work through each section, keep asking: **How does this create obstacles for my characters?**

Not every piece of worldbuilding needs to directly pressure the romance — some details just make the world feel real. But if you find yourself developing elaborate systems that never touch your love story, you might be worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake rather than story's sake.

The best romantasy worldbuilding does double duty: it makes the world feel real *and* it makes the romance feel impossible (until it isn't).

Use the Integration Checks

At the end of each section, you'll find Integration Checks — questions that connect that section's topic to others. These are important.

Worlds feel real when their systems interact. A magic system affects government (who has power). Religion shapes culture (what's taboo). History explains current politics (why the feud exists). Geography determines economy (who controls resources).

If each section exists in isolation, your world will feel like a collection of unrelated details. Integration Checks help you weave everything together.

Examples Are Guides, Not Rules

Throughout this workbook, you'll find examples drawn from popular romantasy novels — ACOTAR, Fourth Wing, From Blood and Ash, Serpent & Dove, and others. These show what good answers look like and what level of specificity is useful.

But these examples aren't templates to copy. Your world should be *yours*. Use the examples to understand the kind of thinking these questions invite, then develop answers that serve your unique story.

A Note on Tropes

Romantasy is a trope-heavy genre, and that's not a weakness — it's a feature. Readers come to romantasy *wanting* enemies-to-lovers, forced proximity, forbidden love, fated mates, morally grey love interests, and “there's only one bed.”

This workbook doesn't shy away from tropes. Instead, it helps you execute them well.

The difference between a tired trope and a beloved one isn't the trope itself — it's the execution. An enemies-to-lovers romance where the enmity is shallow and easily overcome is boring. An enemies-to-lovers romance where both characters have genuine, legitimate reasons to hate each other — where choosing love means betraying everything they believed — that's compelling.

CORE PRINCIPLE

■ *Worldbuilding is how you make tropes feel earned.*

The forced proximity isn't just “they're stuck together” — it's the specific institution, geography, political situation, or magical bond that makes escape impossible.

The forbidden love isn't just “they're not supposed to be together” — it's the specific laws, cultural taboos, religious strictures, or historical enmity that makes their love dangerous.

Build your world to support your tropes, and your tropes will sing.

Before You Begin

You don't need to know your whole story before starting. Many writers discover their plots through worldbuilding — realizing that the magic system they developed creates a perfect obstacle, or that the political situation they built suggests an ending they hadn't considered.

Let the worldbuilding work *with* your story, not as a separate task you complete before writing.

And remember: worldbuilding exists to serve the story. A beautifully detailed world that doesn't create stakes for your characters is just a setting guide. A sparse world that perfectly pressures your romance is doing its job.

Build what you need. Skip what you don't. Make a world worth falling in love in.

The Sections

SECTION	TOPIC	WHAT IT COVERS
1	Geography & Environment	Physical world, climate, travel, how place creates obstacles
2	Flora, Fauna & Ecosystems	Plants, animals, bonded creatures, inter-species romance
3	Culture, Customs & Daily Life	Social norms, taboos, courtship, what's forbidden
4	Economy, Labor & Resources	Wealth, class, debt, what money means for love
5	Government, Power & Law	Politics, law, forbidden relationships, enemies-to-lovers
6	Religion, Myth & Prophecy	Faith, vows, divine purpose, what the gods demand
7	History & Lore	The past that haunts the present, inherited conflict
8	Magic System	How magic works, magical bonds, power dynamics

Additional Sections (9–21) cover specialized topics: technology, time & calendar, language, magic conflicts, pressure cooker settings, institutions, and more.

Appendix A: Revealing Worldbuilding in Prose — A practical guide to deploying your worldbuilding in scenes without info-dumps.

Let's Begin

Turn to whichever section calls to you first. There's no wrong starting point.

Your world is waiting to be built.